

“ ALL THAT SEPARATES
... RACE, CLASS, CREED,
OR SEX, IS INHUMAN, AND
MUST BE OVERCOME. ”

Kate Sheppard, suffragist, in the pamphlet *Is it Right?*, 1892

ALTHOUGH FRANCE HAD MADE GAINS IN THE WEST AFRICAN INTERIOR, the coastal territories around the kingdom of **Dahomey** (present-day Benin) had proven difficult to subdue. In 1889, Britain had handed over to France the coastal city of **Cotonou** in Dahomey without consulting the Dahomeans. The result was the First Franco-Dahomean War (1889–90), which concluded with a treaty that ceded Cotonou and Porto Novo to France in exchange for payments to the king of Dahomey. However, tensions remained, and by 1892 another war had begun, this time over the issue of **slavery**. The king, Behanzin (1844–1906), was still allowing slave raids, despite the abolition of slavery. In addition, he attacked a French gunboat. France retaliated, this time with an army of French and Senegalese troops, and they overpowered the kingdom, bringing it under French control in 1893.



Sugar production in tons
In 1893, Cuba, then the dominant world sugar grower, produced 1 million tons of sugar, four times as much as Jamaica.

Halfway around the world, in the British colony of **New Zealand**, women won the right to vote. The push for women's **suffrage** was gaining momentum in many places, but these islands were the first to grant the right, after formidable efforts by suffragists and tireless campaigners, such as **Kate Sheppard** (1847–1934). Shortly after this act was passed, there was a general election in which 65 percent of women cast their votes.

Meanwhile, **Cuba** was experiencing a sugar boom, with profits of \$64 million in 1893. However, a US **tariff** the following year would cause profits to drop to \$13 million by 1896.

Ruler of Dahomey
A painting of Behanzin, king of Dahomey (modern Benin), shows him holding symbols of kingship while surrounded by attendants.



An engraving showing the coronation ceremony of Emperor Nicholas II and the Empress Alexandra, who would be Russia's last ruling monarchs.

IN RUSSIA, AFTER THE DEATH OF ALEXANDER III, Nicholas II (1868–1918) became the next, and last, emperor of Russia. He presided over an increasingly troubled country, and would not be able to withstand the social **revolution** that engulfed Russia in the early 20th century.

Russia's neighbor, **China**, had become entangled in a local conflict in **Korea** that escalated into the **Sino-Japanese War**. The confrontation had started over an internal revolt in Korea. The monarch asked both nations for help, and both sent troops. Yet they also refused to leave once the rebellion was suppressed. Japan was allied with the modernizing government in Korea, while China backed the royal family. Tensions between China and Japan mounted and

“ I AM NOT YET READY
TO BE CZAR. I KNOW
NOTHING OF THE
BUSINESS OF RULING. ”

Czar Nicholas II, on becoming ruler of Russia, 1894

conflict broke out, with Japan declaring war on China on August 1.

In the Ottoman Empire, the **Christian Armenian** people were also caught up in the nationalist spirit of the time, and they tried to assert their independence. However, their efforts met with a particularly brutal **suppression**, ordered by Sultan Abdul Hamid II (1842–1918). This saw systematic massacres of Armenian people

throughout the empire, resulting in the collapse of the independence movement a few years later. The death toll has been estimated to be around 250,000 Armenians killed out of a population of 2 million, between 1894 and 1897.

Sino-Japanese War
A painting of the Sino-Japanese War shows the Japanese forces conquering Jiulicheng after defeating the Chinese at Pyongyang.



France gains control of Laos

March 10 Côte d'Ivoire becomes a French colony

September 19 New Zealand grants voting rights to women

November Unofficial end to Second Franco-Dahomean War when French enter Cana in Dahomey (present-day Benin)

May Bubonic plague breaks out in Hong Kong killing around 2.5 million by the year's end

June 24 French president Sadi Carnot (b. 1837) assassinated

June 30 Tower Bridge in London opens for traffic

August 1 Sino-Japanese War starts (to 1895) over Japanese attack on Korea

November 1 Last Russian czar, Nicholas II (1868–1918), takes the throne

December 18 First Australian women gain the right to vote and be elected to Parliament